



542 CE

PLAGUE OF JUSTINIAN

The first known epidemic of bubonic plague entered the Byzantine empire through the port of Pelusium in Egypt and then spread, reaching the imperial capital Constantinople, where it left streets littered with corpses. Emperor Justinian contracted the disease, but recovered. The plague claimed around 40 per cent of the population of the eastern Mediterranean, caused huge disruption to agriculture, commerce, and military recruitment, and severely weakened the Byzantine empire.

◀ Prayers for the victims
of the Justinianic Plague

540 CE

550 CE **Kingdom of Ghana founded** - the first of the great West African states

c. 570 CE **Khan Bayam** establishes the Avar kingdom in central Europe

In 542 CE, around 10,000 people died of plague every day in Constantinople

568 CE

LOMBARDS INVADE ITALY

The Lombards, a Germanic people based in Pannonia (modern Hungary) took advantage of the weakness of Byzantine rule following the prolonged war with the Ostrogoths and the

Justinianic Plague to cross the Alps into Italy. Their king Audoin rapidly overran the north, capturing Pavia in 572 CE; however, the Lombard kingdom soon fragmented into feuding duchies.



◀ Detail from helmet
of Lombard king Agilulf